

VirtualDub lets you apply filters in any sequence

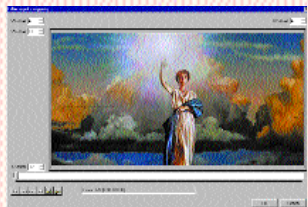
to work on a smaller image and also, you would want the smoothening to work on the resized image for best quality.

Cut video down to size

The size of the video file matters tremendously during post-production as well as for distribution. The larger the file, the longer it will take to process. Also, the video should be small enough to be burnt on a CD or DVD or even published to the Internet, depending on how you want to share it with your friends

Dead space

If the video has a solid border around it, cut it away. Though black bars compress extremely well and may even take no space at all, the sharp edge between the picture and black area takes a lot of space. Video compression



Cut out unnecessary bands from the video

algorithms are meant to optimise the smooth edges in video, not perfectly horizontal or vertical artificial breaks. Normally, compressors break the image into 8x8 or 16x16 blocks and the borders will not affect much if they conform to these boundaries. However, if they don't, the compressor will either use a lot of space for forming those perfect edges, or smear them.

Image ratio

If you intend to compress the video with DivX, the final movie size should be in multiples of 16 pixels. Sometimes it can be in multiples of 8 and, very rarely, 32. Thus, a 320x240 video will compress well with DivX, but 321x240 will not.

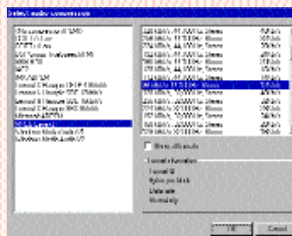
Manageably large

When capturing video, pick a frame size close to the final output. If you're going to make a 320x240 video, it doesn't make much sense to capture at 640x480, since it takes four times the space to do so. Ordinarily, do not set the frame rate higher than 30 fps.

Compress audio

AVI files with CD-quality audio (176 Kbps) are quite a waste of space, especially for home videos. For distribution, 8-bit audio at 44 KHz is good enough. Also, compress the audio with a codec. This will reduce the size of the audio to between half and a quarter of

its original size with very little loss in quality. MP3 is the best codec to encode audio. However, on slow machines it can cause synchronisation problems in the video.



Choose an audio compression codec in VirtualDub

Nix Intros and Trailers

Use computer-generated graphics sparingly with video. Video compressors are adapted to natural images and do not perform optimally on saturated colours and sharp edges. Depending on the codec, title screens and overlay items can adversely affect video quality, especially at low bitrates.

If you must include them, make openings and trailers independent—don't use transitions to blend them with the video and have them start and end on keyframe boundaries. Align the position and size of overlay items to 8x8 or 16x16 pixel boundaries and make them opaque. Transparent regions on the logo will be translated as a complex tile by the codec and will take up a lot of space. If the logo is opaque, the codec will ignore



Video@Home

The *Blair Witch Project* proved that great video is possible with low-end equipment. This movie was shot on Hi-8, a low level video format with a camera that had a one-colour chip instead of the usual three on professional equipment. Only a simple camera-mounted light was used.

it between keyframes, saving a lot of overheads.

Don't pack video

There is no use compressing video files to ZIP, RAR, etc. Compression greater than 2 per cent means the video itself is not constructed correctly. You will need three times the space of the video to pack it and so will the person viewing the video. Also, viewing partial downloads becomes impossible. If the video is distributed as it is, depending on the codec, a partial download can be viewed or repaired.

DivX

DivX is the latest in video compression technology. It affords very high quality video in very small files using MPEG4 compression. This is the best codec to use, especially for distributing video. DivX 5, the latest version, uses variable bitrates (VBR)



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